

1. Freud Daydreaming

Objective of the Essay

Freud's essay explores the psychological origins of creative writing. He argues that the imaginative activity of writers originates from the same source as childhood play and adult daydreams: the fulfillment of unexpressed wishes. The essay connects literature, fantasy, and unconscious desire, showing how personal fantasies are transformed into artistic expression.

Imagination and Childhood Play

Freud begins by identifying children's play as the earliest form of imaginative activity. In play, children create their own worlds by modifying reality to suit their desires. Although they are emotionally invested in their play, children understand that it is not real. This separation between imagination and reality forms the basis for later creative work.

The Role of Daydreams

As people grow older, they stop playing but continue to engage in daydreaming or fantasy, often in secret. These daydreams are substitutes for childhood play and serve a similar function: the imaginative realization of unfulfilled desires. Adults tend to conceal their fantasies because they are often egocentric or socially inappropriate. Nonetheless, Freud argues that almost everyone fantasizes at some point.

Motivation Behind Fantasy

Fantasy arises from unfulfilled wishes. Freud identifies two major types: **1)** Ambitious fantasies, related to self-importance and success. **2)** Erotic fantasies, related to love and desire.

These often appear together. For example, a person may imagine achieving success and being admired or loved as a result. The content of fantasies varies with the individual's personality, circumstances, and psychological development.

Temporal Structure of Fantasy

Freud notes that fantasies often involve three distinct time elements: **1)** A present stimulus or triggering event. **2)** A memory from the past, often childhood, where a similar desire was first experienced. **3)** A future scenario in which the wish is fulfilled.

He illustrates this with an example of a poor boy who imagines becoming successful and loved. The fantasy connects his current situation, a memory of past security, and a hopeful vision of future success.

Creative Writing as Public Daydreaming

Freud compares the creative writer to the daydreamer, but with important differences. While ordinary individuals conceal their fantasies, the writer presents them openly, albeit in a disguised and artistically structured form. This transformation allows readers to accept and even enjoy the writer's fantasies without discomfort.

Emotional Impact and Aesthetic Pleasure

The writer uses artistic techniques to make their fantasies acceptable and pleasurable to others. Freud suggests two primary methods: **1)** Disguising personal fantasies through fictional characters and events. **2)** Offering aesthetic pleasure, which Freud calls a "bribe," to make the emotional content easier to receive.

This aesthetic enjoyment allows the reader to engage with otherwise private or shameful thoughts in a socially acceptable way.

Common Traits in Literature

Freud points out certain recurring features in popular fiction, particularly in novels and romances:

- The hero is central, often idealized, and always survives.
The heroine loves him, and other characters are either helpers or obstacles.
These stories reflect the writer's own fantasies, with the hero often representing the writer's ideal self.

Even more complex forms of literature, such as psychological novels, tend to reflect the writer's inner life, often splitting different aspects of the self into multiple characters.

Relation to Dreams and Pathology

Freud draws a connection between daydreams, creative writing, and night dreams. Dreams also fulfill wishes, though they are more hidden due to repression. When fantasies become excessive or dominate the individual's thinking, they can lead to neurosis or mental illness. Thus, fantasy plays a significant role both in creativity and in psychological disorders.

Literature and the Audience

Freud acknowledges that readers experience pleasure when engaging with literary works, even if the content includes pain, loss, or conflict. This is due to the form and emotional structure the writer employs. Literature, therefore, allows readers to confront deep desires indirectly, freeing emotional tension in a satisfying way.

Conclusion

Freud concludes that creative writing is an extension and refinement of childhood play and adult fantasy. It arises from personal wishes and emotional needs, but is transformed by the writer into an artistic product that others can enjoy. The writer's success lies in shaping private fantasies into public forms that offer both aesthetic and emotional satisfaction.

2. Barthes Roland Camera Lucida Reflections on Photography

Introduction

In *Camera Lucida*, Roland Barthes embarks on a philosophical and personal inquiry into the nature of photography. Prompted by the death of his mother, Barthes explores not only what photography is, but also what it uniquely communicates that no other medium can. Rather than treating photography as a technical or historical subject, Barthes focuses on its existential and emotional dimensions, searching for its essence through phenomenological reflection and autobiographical memory.

The Ontological Inquiry

Barthes begins with an ontological question: what makes photography distinct from other visual arts? While painting and cinema are expressive and representational, Barthes seeks to determine what photography is "in itself." He is not satisfied by definitions based on technical processes. Instead, he aims to understand photography based on how it affects the viewer and what kind of truth it delivers.

His analysis distinguishes photography from cinema by noting that while cinema presents moving images that unfold over time, photography captures a single moment, an arrested slice of time. For Barthes, the photograph uniquely testifies that "this has been"—it confirms the presence of a real object or person at a particular moment in the past. This recognition becomes central to his exploration of how photographs produce emotional and intellectual responses.

The Dual Structure: Studium and Punctum

One of the key contributions of Barthes' text is the distinction he introduces between two elements present in photographs: the *studium* and the *punctum*.

The *studium* refers to the cultural, historical, and informational context of a photograph. It represents the photographer's intended meaning or the general interest a viewer might have in the image. This is the part of a photograph that can be explained, interpreted, and shared. The *studium* evokes an understanding or recognition, often aligned with societal conventions or aesthetics.

The *punctum*, by contrast, is the element that pierces the viewer on a personal, emotional level. It is not necessarily intended by the photographer but is something incidental or accidental that stands out, wounds, or "pricks" the observer. It triggers a subjective and sometimes unconscious connection, often producing a deep emotional response. Unlike the *studium*, the *punctum* cannot be coded or generalized; it is immediate and intensely individual.

The Photograph and the Subject

Barthes further reflects on the relationship between the subject of a photograph and the viewer. He discusses the experience of being photographed, describing how posing in front of a camera induces a kind of split identity: the subject becomes both observer and observed, self and object. The moment of being photographed becomes performative, as one becomes conscious of the image one is producing.

For Barthes, this experience is unsettling. The photograph fixes the self into an image, which always risks being inauthentic. It creates a tension between one's living, changeable identity and the static, visual record captured in the photograph.

Photography and Death

Death is one of the central themes of *Camera Lucida*. Barthes argues that every photograph contains an element of death because it preserves a moment that is no longer present. The photographic image inevitably gestures toward a past that has vanished. This confrontation with mortality is particularly powerful in portrait photography. To be photographed is to be turned into an image that will outlive the subject, and to view such a photograph is to witness a person who is no longer alive—or who will eventually die.

This theme becomes especially poignant when Barthes discusses the final photograph of his mother, referred to as the “Winter Garden Photograph.” Although he does not reproduce this image in the book, he describes it as capturing the essence of her being and as providing a moment of recognition beyond mere representation. It becomes, for him, the “just image,” not simply accurate but just in the ethical sense: an image that does justice to her memory.

The Haunting Effect of Photographs

Barthes emphasizes the haunting, spectral quality of photography. A photograph, while depicting reality, also evokes a ghostly presence. It fixes a person or scene in time, presenting a living reality that is already dead or passing. He compares photography to theater and myth, suggesting that the photographic portrait can act as a kind of death mask—a visible sign of what is no longer living.

The haunting is also personal. Barthes describes the experience of looking at photographs as one marked by both recognition and loss. While he may recognize certain features or expressions in a photograph of his mother, he often fails to fully “find” her. Most images offer only fragments or approximations of her being. It is only in the Winter Garden Photograph that he perceives a total and essential expression of who she was.

The Subjective Encounter

For Barthes, the meaning of a photograph is not solely determined by the photographer or by cultural context, but by the individual who looks at it. The viewer brings their own memories, desires, and associations to the act of seeing. This subjectivity is what makes the *punctum* possible. It also explains why different photographs affect different viewers in different ways.

Photography, in this sense, resists total explanation. It is not governed purely by aesthetic or informational rules, but by the unpredictable emotional reactions it elicits. The experience of viewing a photograph cannot be reduced to knowledge or cultural interpretation alone.

Conclusion

Camera Lucida is not a technical or theoretical treatise on photography, but a deeply personal meditation on its significance. Barthes combines philosophical inquiry with autobiographical reflection, resulting in a work that examines how photographs move us, how they relate to time and memory, and how they expose us to the presence of absence. He finds in photography not merely a record of the visible world, but an encounter with loss, identity, and love.

In the end, the photograph becomes a paradox: it confirms presence while revealing absence, it preserves while pointing to what is no longer, and it offers knowledge while resisting full understanding. Through this reflection, Barthes gives us not a science of photography, but a poetics of photographic experience.

3. Mirror Selections

This essay explores the multifaceted symbolism, psychology, aesthetics, and cultural significance of mirrors across literature, philosophy, art, and psychoanalysis. Rather than focusing solely on their optical or reflective properties, the mirror is treated as a metaphor for identity, alterity, perception, illusion, and the unconscious. The text navigates through various historical and literary instances, unraveling how the mirror becomes a site of both revelation and distortion, intimacy and alienation, seduction and disintegration.

Mirrors and Self-Perception

The essay begins with an anecdote about a man who places a mirror by his bed to observe himself while asleep, a futile gesture revealing the inherent limits of reflection. The mirror may offer an image, but it always withholds part of the self, particularly the unconscious or the unseen. This moment introduces the central theme: the tension between what the mirror reveals and what it conceals. As in Proust’s reflections and Freud’s uncanny mirror scene, the mirror is capable of startling the observer by confronting them with the unfamiliar within the familiar—the other in the self.

Obliqueness and the Disruption of Identity

The mirror is not merely a passive object but one that may deceive or disturb. Sideways glances and oblique reflections subvert the straightforward image and expose another truth—one not bound by symmetry or proportion. The distortion inherent in mirrored reflections implies duplicity, and even in beauty, a “dubious

resemblance" may emerge. Montaigne's self-portraits exemplify this oblique self-discovery, where the self is found more often by chance than through conscious introspection. The oblique mirror thus becomes a means through which the self encounters its own strangeness.

Love, Desire, and Catoptric Games

Mirrors also play a central role in scenarios of love and desire. They mediate between reality and fantasy, often allowing secret or forbidden feelings to emerge. Rousseau's episode with Madame Basile demonstrates how the mirror transforms a private desire into an aesthetic moment, with the reflection revealing what is hidden from direct gaze. This moment not only externalizes desire but also protects it, allowing it to exist without immediate consequence. Similarly, Goethe's use of the mirror in *Wilhelm Meister's Travels* emphasizes the mirror's ability to reflect and intensify emotional truth, situating the mirror as both a literal and metaphorical frame for love, fantasy, and narrative.

Anamorphosis and Optical Illusion

The mirror's capacity for distortion is explored in the context of anamorphosis, a technique where an image appears fragmented or meaningless until viewed from a specific angle. This distortion serves both as an artistic device and as a metaphor for hidden or repressed truths. Holbein's *The Ambassadors* is cited as a key example: a skull, visible only from a certain perspective, disrupts the otherwise formal and stately composition, serving as a memento mori and a critique of worldly vanity. This manipulation of perception mirrors the workings of the unconscious, revealing death and disintegration where the surface suggests order and unity.

Mirrors and the Hallucinatory

The mirror's illusions are likened to hallucinations, where rationality confronts its limits. Renaissance experiments with optics and catoptrics reflect a fascination with controlling illusion through science, yet even scientific manipulations do not escape their enchantment. Devices like the magic lantern and metamorphosis machines project distorted or hybrid images, producing wonder and fear simultaneously. The mirror thus becomes both a scientific tool and a device of dream and fantasy, capable of uncovering layers of illusion, metaphor, and deception.

Mirrors in Social and Erotic Spaces

In the libertine cultures of the eighteenth century, mirrors became essential to the architecture of pleasure. Boudoirs were designed to stimulate sensuality, with mirrors carefully arranged to alternate concealment and revelation. The mirror here functions not only as a tool of self-contemplation but also of social interaction and erotic display. The spectacle of the self is not merely narcissistic but mediated by desire and gaze. Mirrors stimulate imagination and prolong the experience of pleasure, creating a space where fantasy and reality are entangled.

Psychological and Pathological Dimensions

The essay shifts to a psychoanalytic perspective, exploring the mirror's role in the development of self-awareness and its potential to trigger anxiety or dissociation. Drawing from Lacanian theory, it acknowledges the mirror stage as central to the formation of the ego, yet also highlights how the image in the mirror can betray or fragment the self. Cases where individuals experience fear, distortion, or non-recognition in their own reflection are presented as evidence of the mirror's instability. The reflection may no longer function symbolically but instead becomes an object of persecution or fear.

Fragility of Identity and the Impossibility of Full Recognition

Self-recognition in the mirror is shown to be partial, fragile, and easily disrupted. The reflected image is ephemeral and subject to misperception. Even with advances in photography and video, people often misremember or misrecognize their own appearance. The mirror thus does not provide a stable identity, but a shifting approximation. Writers like Barthes and Simone Weil emphasize the disjunction between the self and the image. The self is fluid and dispersed, while the image is fixed and objectified. This disjunction can cause existential discomfort, particularly when the mirrored image is seen as a caricature or a distortion of the inner self.

Mirrors and Mortality

To look into a mirror is to confront one's mortality. The reflection bears witness to change, decay, and impermanence. The Shakespearean example of King Richard II dramatizes this confrontation, as the mirror becomes a tool of self-examination and loss. The image reflects not only the current face but also its transformation and eventual disappearance. The essay ends by reaffirming that any mirror is also a mirror of vanity, and any reflection of the self inevitably gestures toward death. The mirror thus operates as both a means of self-knowledge and a reminder of the limitations of that knowledge.

4. Mulvey Visual Pleasure

Laura Mulvey's *Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema* is a groundbreaking feminist critique of classical Hollywood cinema. The essay draws upon psychoanalytic theory, especially Freud and Lacan, to analyze how traditional film structures visual pleasure through gendered dynamics of looking. Mulvey argues that mainstream narrative cinema is shaped by and reinforces a patriarchal order in which woman exists primarily as an object of male desire, while man is positioned as the bearer of the gaze. Her goal is not merely to critique, but to propose how alternative cinemas might disrupt these mechanisms.

Psychoanalysis as a Political Tool

Mulvey appropriates psychoanalysis not to reinforce existing gendered structures, but to expose how deeply rooted they are in both individual psychology and cultural production. She identifies phallocentrism as a system that depends on the image of woman as lacking—in anatomical and symbolic terms—to generate meaning. Woman's function in patriarchal unconscious structures is twofold: she signifies the threat of castration and simultaneously facilitates a boy's entrance into the symbolic order. Once this function is fulfilled, the woman's role ends. She remains only as a symbolic absence or memory, locked in a structure that makes her bearer of meaning but never the producer of it. Mulvey notes that while psychoanalysis itself emerges from within this phallogentric system, it can nonetheless help feminists to understand the mechanisms of visual control and desire in cinema.

The Destruction of Pleasure as a Radical Weapon

Mulvey states that in order to challenge mainstream cinema, it is necessary to disrupt the pleasure it provides. Hollywood cinema, particularly in its classical form, is built on satisfying visual pleasure that aligns with patriarchal values. This includes scopophilia (pleasure in looking) and narcissistic identification. Her strategy is not to moralistically reject mainstream film but to critically analyze its structure and expose how visual and narrative techniques reinforce male dominance. She argues that feminist cinema must destroy the comfort and completeness of narrative pleasure in order to open up space for new expressions of desire and identity.

Pleasure in Looking and the Fascination with the Human Form

Mulvey identifies two central forms of visual pleasure in cinema. The first is scopophilia, the pleasure derived from looking at others as objects. This is often voyeuristic and controlling, turning women into passive visual objects for male satisfaction. The second is narcissistic, emerging from the identification with an idealized image of oneself on screen. Drawing on Lacan's concept of the mirror stage, Mulvey describes how the child's recognition of their own image as whole and ideal forms the basis of ego construction. Cinema, with its enclosed visual field and emphasis on the human figure, reproduces this mirror-like effect, allowing spectators to temporarily lose themselves in the identification with characters, particularly male protagonists.

These two types of pleasure—voyeuristic and narcissistic—often coexist and are fused within mainstream cinema. The film structures allow the viewer to maintain a distance from the image while simultaneously identifying with it. This dynamic is deeply rooted in the symbolic order, shaped by language and desire, and constantly returns to the foundational trauma of the castration complex. In this symbolic framework, the woman becomes the site where desire is projected and controlled.

Woman as Image. Man as Bearer of the Look

In traditional narrative cinema, the gaze is structured along gendered lines. The male is the active agent who looks, while the female is the passive object who is looked at. The woman, therefore, is displayed as a spectacle for both the male characters within the film and the male spectator in the audience. Her appearance disrupts narrative continuity, momentarily halting the plot to offer visual pleasure. Yet this display must be reabsorbed into the narrative, often by subordinating her to the male protagonist's desire.

The male protagonist acts as a proxy for the viewer, enabling the spectator to identify with him and share in his control over the female figure. This identification supports male power by aligning it with narrative progression and agency. The woman, by contrast, is not allowed agency; she represents sexual difference, and her body becomes a signifier of lack—a constant reminder of castration that both fascinates and terrifies.

Fetishism and Voyeurism as Defenses Against Castration Anxiety

Mulvey explains that the female image evokes castration anxiety for the male unconscious. Two primary mechanisms are employed in cinema to manage this anxiety: voyeurism and fetishistic scopophilia. Voyeurism operates by subjecting the woman to investigation, punishment, or redemption within the narrative structure. This is aligned with sadistic tendencies and narrative momentum. Fetishistic scopophilia, on the other hand, transforms the woman into a reassuring object of beauty—glamorous, untouchable, and aesthetically perfected—detached from narrative time.

Mulvey discusses how different directors use these mechanisms. In Josef von Sternberg's films with Marlene Dietrich, for example, the image of the woman becomes the central spectacle, stylized to the point of fetishism.

The narrative becomes secondary, and the woman's beauty dominates the frame. In contrast, Hitchcock's films such as *Vertigo*, *Rear Window*, and *Marnie* employ voyeurism. The male protagonist is often a proxy for the spectator, whose gaze is directed toward the woman in a controlling and sometimes punishing way. Through his complex use of point-of-view shots and subjective camera, Hitchcock reveals the perverse implications of visual pleasure and complicity in the gaze.

Disrupting the Classical Gaze

Mulvey argues that classical narrative film works by concealing the mechanisms of looking. There are three looks involved in cinema: the look of the camera recording the scene, the look of the characters at one another within the film, and the look of the audience watching the screen. Traditional cinema hides the first and second, privileging the third. The result is an illusion of seamless realism and narrative coherence. However, this illusion relies on the suppression of the spectator's awareness of their own gaze and of the camera's presence.

By making the mechanisms of looking visible and by denying visual pleasure, radical cinema can disrupt these patterns. Mulvey calls for an avant-garde cinema that reveals the constructedness of the gaze and allows for new relationships between image, narrative, and desire. This would not merely replace one form of pleasure with another but would destabilize the codes of patriarchal visibility entirely.

Conclusion

Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema remains a foundational text in feminist film theory because of its rigorous application of psychoanalytic concepts to cinematic representation. Mulvey demonstrates how mainstream cinema has historically constructed a gendered system of looking that privileges male desire and relegates women to passive spectacle. By analyzing how scopophilia and narcissistic identification operate in visual narrative, and by revealing the ideological implications of cinematic codes, Mulvey calls for a radical rethinking of film form. She urges feminist filmmakers and critics to challenge traditional aesthetics and to develop new visual languages that do not depend on voyeurism, fetishism, or the objectification of women.

5. Simmel- The Handle

In this essay, Georg Simmel offers a philosophical and aesthetic meditation on the vase handle, using it as a symbolic and conceptual entry point to explore the relationship between art and utility, form and function, the internal and external, and ultimately between the self-contained and the socially connected. Through a careful examination of this seemingly minor component, Simmel unfolds a theory of aesthetic duality and existential significance that extends beyond object analysis to reflect on broader human and metaphysical concerns.

The Artwork's Dual Existence

Simmel begins by distinguishing between the space of art and the space of real life. While real objects exist within infinite, tactile space, works of art—like paintings and sculptures—occupy a closed, ideal space. Artworks are detached from reality; they are self-contained and inwardly unified, even though they derive their content from the real world. A vase, when viewed purely as an artwork, shares this detachment. However, as a functional object designed to be held, used, and moved within practical life, the vase also exists within the everyday world.

The Vase as a Dual Entity

Unlike purely visual artworks, the vase is situated at the intersection of two realms: it possesses both aesthetic and utilitarian value. Its material composition is part of the real world, but its form can evoke aesthetic contemplation. This duality is uniquely and most clearly expressed through the handle, which connects the vase physically and symbolically to its practical context. The handle is designed to facilitate interaction with the object, yet it must also integrate visually and conceptually with the artistic unity of the vase as a whole.

The Aesthetic Problem of the Handle

The handle embodies a tension between external purpose and internal aesthetic form. It must be capable of being used, but also appear harmonious with the overall design. In cases where the handle seems merely affixed—especially when styled as animals such as snakes or dragons—it suggests its external origin and its intrusion upon the unity of the vessel. In other cases, handles appear to grow seamlessly from the body of the vase, reinforcing a sense of organic unity, like the way human arms extend from the torso.

Simmel discusses how certain bowls, particularly from ancient Central American cultures, are shaped in such a way that the handle and the bowl resemble a stem and leaf. In these instances, the handle becomes an extension of the user's hand, channeling the soul's intent into the object. It becomes a metaphor for the transfer of inner life into material form, demonstrating the subtlety and richness of an object that is both functional and symbolically expressive.

Disharmony and Aesthetic Failure

When a vase's handle emphasizes either function or form to the exclusion of the other, the result is aesthetically unsatisfying. Simmel offers examples of this: handles that are merely ornamental and fully attached to the body, rendering them unusable, or others that include multiple handles serving contradictory functions, leading to a fragmented aesthetic perception. He argues that when multiple movements are suggested by multiple handles but only one can be performed at a time, the object becomes visually and functionally incoherent.

Another aesthetic failure occurs when fixed handles imitate the appearance of movable ones made of different materials, as in certain Japanese porcelain teapots. Here, the artificial suggestion of a different material highlights the disjunction between appearance and reality, between unity and external intrusion. The vase's autonomy is violated by this mimetic gesture, and the handle no longer serves as a genuine point of interaction between art and the world.

The Symbolic Role of the Handle

Simmel then expands the discussion by likening the handle and spout of the vase to the two modes of human engagement with the world. The handle allows the external world to approach and manipulate the vase, while the spout allows the vase to act upon the world. The handle is centripetal, drawing the object into a system of usage; the spout is centrifugal, projecting it outward in purpose. Both are part of the vase, yet both serve to integrate it with its external environment.

This dual function is symbolic of broader philosophical structures: the soul, too, interacts with the world by receiving and projecting through sensory and volitional acts. The handle, then, becomes a metaphor for the interface between self-contained wholeness and external teleology. When a handle fulfills both its formal and functional roles harmoniously, it achieves a higher kind of beauty—what Simmel calls a “superaesthetic” form. This is a unity that transcends mere formal beauty or functional success, capturing the deeper, often symbolic, integration of internal coherence and external significance.

Extension to the Human Condition

In the final portion of the essay, Simmel generalizes his analysis into a reflection on human life. He suggests that individuals, like vases, exist within multiple spheres of meaning—personal, social, political, ethical—and must often serve purposes imposed by larger systems. A well-lived life, like a well-designed vase, preserves the unity of the individual self while accommodating the claims of external teleologies.

Just as the handle should not disrupt the aesthetic unity of the vase but must nonetheless allow for external engagement, so too must the human being maintain inner coherence while engaging in service to broader causes or ideals. The richness of life, according to Simmel, lies in this capacity to simultaneously belong to multiple orders of meaning, to be both whole in oneself and open to the other.

Conclusion

Simmel concludes by suggesting that the humble handle, precisely because of its apparently marginal role, reveals a profound philosophical and aesthetic truth. It symbolizes the intersection of autonomy and relationality, of beauty and purpose, of self and world. The essay affirms that the fullest expression of form, whether in art or life, lies in achieving harmony between internal integrity and external functionality. In this way, the handle becomes a figure for the human soul: rooted in one domain, reaching out to another, seeking to unify both without disintegration.

6. Benjamin - Baudelaire Selections

Walter Benjamin's essay on Charles Baudelaire offers a layered examination of modern urban life, sensory experience, alienation, and the transformation of poetic form under capitalist modernity. Through Baudelaire's poetry and his relation to literary predecessors such as Edgar Allan Poe, Benjamin constructs a critical theory of perception in the age of industrialization, focusing on concepts such as shock, crowd experience, memory, and the dissolution of traditional experience. Baudelaire becomes for Benjamin not only a poet of the city, but also a historical witness to the transformations of subjectivity in the age of mechanical reproduction and capitalist labor.

The Poet and the Urban Crowd

Benjamin begins by considering the figure of the urban poet in relation to the modern metropolis. In contrast to the romantic ideal of the solitary poet communing with nature, the modern poet is embedded in the crowd, yet not truly part of it. Baudelaire's poetry captures the contradictions of city life: fascination and alienation, sensuality and anonymity, stimulation and solitude. He is particularly drawn to the figure of the unknown woman in the crowd, seen fleetingly and lost forever. This motif—what Benjamin calls “love at last sight”—is emblematic of the modern experience of urban beauty: intense, transient, and unfulfilled. The crowd is no longer a threatening, chaotic force but rather the backdrop for modern shock experience and erotic projection.

Poe's “The Man of the Crowd” and the Pathology of the Flâneur

Benjamin traces the literary lineage of the flâneur—a detached urban observer—to Edgar Allan Poe’s story “The Man of the Crowd,” which Baudelaire translated and admired. Poe’s narrator, recovering from illness, becomes mesmerized by the anonymous flow of people in the streets of London. He follows a mysterious figure who never leaves the crowd, a man whose identity seems fused with the urban flux. Benjamin distinguishes between Poe’s “man of the crowd” and the Parisian flâneur. The former is manic and compulsively embedded in the mass, while the flâneur is a detached, leisurely figure who strolls and observes without commitment. The contrast reflects differing stages of urban development and psychological adaptation to the crowd.

Baudelaire’s Paris still permitted the flâneur to exist, with its covered arcades and leisurely promenades, unlike London’s harsh industrial sprawl. However, Benjamin suggests that even Baudelaire’s flâneur was increasingly out of place. As capitalist modernity advanced, the flâneur became a relic, unable to maintain his contemplative distance amid the accelerating pace and fragmentation of modern life.

From Aesthetic Contemplation to Mechanical Perception

Benjamin explores how industrialization transformed sensory experience. In earlier periods, perception involved slow contemplation and sustained attention. With the rise of urban capitalism, however, daily life became marked by shock, interruption, and rapid shifts in sensory stimuli. This new perceptual regime is both represented and processed in Baudelaire’s poetry. The poet becomes a figure who internalizes the trauma of modern life, translating it into stylized, symbolic language.

Technology plays a key role in this transformation. The invention of the match, the telephone, and the camera introduced a culture of instantaneity and mechanical gestures. For Benjamin, the photograph’s “snap” is emblematic of modern shock perception: a single, arbitrary gesture that fixes a fleeting moment. The cinema extends this further by organizing perception around cuts and montage, echoing the repetitive rhythm of the factory conveyor belt. Modern individuals are trained by these shocks to respond automatically, with reduced scope for reflective experience.

The Alienation of Labor and the Loss of Experience

Benjamin draws upon Marx’s analysis of industrial labor to explain how modern workers are subjected to repetitive, meaningless motions that strip their actions of traditional significance. The unskilled factory laborer performs gestures that are detached from the learning process of practice. This loss of continuity, duration, and development in work mirrors the breakdown of personal experience, or *Erfahrung*, in modern life. In Benjamin’s view, Baudelaire, though not fully aware of factory conditions, expresses a kindred alienation in his representation of the gambler.

Gambling, like factory work, involves mechanical repetition and a lack of connection between past and present actions. The gambler entrusts his fate to a mechanism he cannot control, performing a gesture that is detached from learning or experience. Baudelaire’s poem “Le Jeu” presents gamblers not as free agents of desire but as compulsive figures caught in a cycle of defeat. Their gestures echo those of the laborer, and their isolation reflects the modern soul’s disconnection from both meaning and memory.

Time, Memory, and the Loss of Fulfillment

In the final sections, Benjamin considers how Baudelaire’s modernity transforms the structure of time. Drawing on Bergson and Proust, Benjamin argues that modern life fragments time into meaningless instants, robbing individuals of sustained memory and fulfillment. True wishes, grounded in lived experience and oriented toward the future, require duration and continuity. Gambling—and by extension, wage labor—operates on the opposite principle: isolated gestures repeated ad infinitum without depth.

Baudelaire’s engagement with time is haunted by impatience, a condition that opposes the kind of experiential fullness Proust seeks in involuntary memory. The ticking of the clock, represented in “Le Jeu” by the image of the second-hand, becomes a symbol of inescapable defeat. Time no longer completes or redeems; it consumes without reward. The poet, even in moments of lucidity, is consigned to the margins of this temporal regime—conscious of what is lost but unable to reclaim it.

Conclusion

Walter Benjamin’s reflections on Baudelaire are not only a study of a poet but a historical meditation on the fate of the individual in capitalist modernity. Through his interpretation of motifs such as the crowd, the flâneur, shock, gambling, and mechanical perception, Benjamin reveals how Baudelaire captures a world in which traditional experience is shattered. The poet becomes a witness to the transformation of consciousness itself, shaped by commodity culture, technological mediation, and the industrial labor system. Ultimately, Baudelaire’s greatness lies in his ability to transform the fragmentary and traumatic features of modern life into poetic images that confront, rather than conceal, the pathologies of his age.

7. Plotnick- Electric Push Buttons Switch

The article begins with a reflection from Dorothy Canfield Fisher in 1916, expressing concern that electric push buttons made electrical services so easy and opaque that users became disconnected from the technology behind them. The author, Rachel Plotnick, uses this concern to launch an investigation into how society interacted with and understood push buttons from 1880 to 1923.

Two Phases of Development

Plotnick divides the push button's evolution into two main phases. The first phase (1880–1915) saw widespread experimentation with how buttons should be used and understood. Some groups encouraged public education about how buttons and electricity worked, while others marketed buttons as easy and effortless tools for avoiding the complexity of electrical technology. The second phase (1915–1923) saw buttons becoming “black boxes”—objects so familiar that people no longer questioned how they worked.

Social and Cultural Meanings

The push button is discussed not only as a technological tool but as a cultural symbol that changed how people interacted with machines. The article argues that push buttons acted as interfaces between users and complex technologies, shaping how people thought about electricity and their own agency. Interfaces like buttons influenced users' behavior and were deeply embedded in societal beliefs about modernity, gender roles, and technological progress.

Material and Technical Evolution

The word “button” evolved from a simple clothing fastener to a mechanical device. By the late 19th century, push buttons were made to control electric circuits, offering on/off capabilities. Early buttons were simple, costly, and rare, but quickly diversified and became affordable, with hundreds of designs by the early 20th century. Inventors focused on making them easy to use, durable, and aesthetically pleasing for integration into homes.

Educational Strategies and Public Engagement

During the early years, schools, books, and magazines actively taught children and adults how push buttons worked, often through hands-on experiments. This educational push aimed to reduce public anxiety about electricity and to encourage scientific thinking. Children were taught to build buzzers and bells with buttons, while adults received instructions on home wiring and repair. Women were also targeted with education to manage household electrical systems.

Industry Marketing and Simplification

Contrasting with educators, electrical companies marketed push buttons as magical, effortless tools. Ads depicted buttons as granting immediate power—like summoning servants or turning on lights—without needing to understand the mechanisms. Push buttons became associated with wealth, comfort, and modern living. Events like the World's Columbian Exposition used buttons as part of public attractions to promote electric culture.

Shift in Perspective Around 1915

As electricity became more common and reliable, users became less curious and more dependent on push buttons. This passive relationship worried electric companies, who now struggled to convince consumers of the value and complexity behind their services. The National Electric Light Association (NELA) and companies like General Electric launched campaigns to re-educate the public, explaining what happened “behind the button.” Posters, advertisements, and films were used to show the wiring, machinery, and human labor involved in delivering electricity.

Conclusion

By 1921, industry leaders recognized they had over-simplified the electric push button. Their promotional strategies had caused the public to undervalue the vast infrastructure behind electricity. The author argues that the history of user interfaces—like push buttons—should be studied more deeply because they reflect how people understand and interact with technology. Push buttons, while small and mundane, mediated powerful social, technological, and educational changes. They symbolized a broader shift in human–machine relationships and reveal much about societal attitudes toward innovation, simplicity, and control.

8. The Misuse Value of the TV Set: Reading Media Objects in Transnational Urban Spaces

Anna McCarthy explores how television sets, especially those placed in public spaces outside homes (like stores and restaurants), are not only used for viewing content but also become part of expressive, material displays she calls “TV settings.” These installations often include personal objects, decorations, religious items, and advertisements placed around the TV. The study focuses on how such displays, especially in immigrant-run businesses in urban USA, express complex cultural identities and experiences related to transnational life.

Concept of “Misuse Value”

McCarthy uses the idea of “misuse value” from literary critic Bill Brown, which means using objects in ways that go beyond their intended function. In this case, the TV is not just a screen to watch but a surface and a stand for displaying cultural signs. These uses show creativity and adaptation, especially among immigrant communities, who transform TV sets into cultural statements.

TV as Material and Social Object

TV sets in these environments become part of everyday social life and expression. Unlike in homes, where television is usually centered around entertainment, in public immigrant spaces, TVs are surrounded by religious icons, tourist souvenirs, photographs, and decorative objects. These objects create what scholars call an “object code,” where meaning is communicated through physical arrangement rather than words alone.

Examples and Analysis

The article uses photographs to document several real-life examples. In a pizzeria named Bella Italia, the TV is surrounded by Italian souvenirs, religious images, a satellite receiver, and even a surveillance camera. These elements blend cultural pride, nostalgia, practicality, and identity. The arrangement is deliberate, but also layered in meaning and purpose.

In other places like Indian or Chinese restaurants, the TV may be placed next to religious shrines, sometimes on top of refrigerators due to space limitations. These juxtapositions are both practical and symbolic. The coexistence of the sacred and the commercial, the old and the new, suggests that meanings are not fixed or singular but shaped by context.

TV Settings as Space-Binding Media

TV in these settings connects people to both local surroundings and distant homelands. For instance, in Bella Italia, souvenir plates and Italian language broadcasts create an atmosphere where Italy feels present. Similarly, a Russian deli in San Francisco shows Russian TV content alongside food posters and promotional magnets, creating a hybrid cultural environment.

The TV setting brings together the live, moving images of satellite broadcasts with still, decorative artifacts of memory and culture. This blurs the line between past and present, here and there. It also shows how immigrant communities negotiate identity through a mix of global media and local expression.

Practical vs. Symbolic Use

A central theme of the article is that practical and symbolic uses of TV and surrounding objects are not separate. A TV might be placed high to be safe, but its position also gives it prominence like a sacred image. When questioned about why certain items are placed around the TV, shopkeepers often reply with casual indifference—“That’s just where we put our stuff”—highlighting how meaning can arise from ordinary actions.

Even mundane actions like sticking a sign on the TV (“Do not touch”) or decorating it with magnets and stickers reflect creative agency and speak to deeper social meanings about space, identity, and belonging.

Commercial Aesthetics and Small Retail Culture

McCarthy criticizes how scholars often ignore the visual culture of small, everyday retail spaces, focusing instead on flashy malls or chain stores. But in these modest settings, displays are rich with meaning. Posters, calendars, religious imagery, and personal items blend capitalist, cultural, and emotional elements. These displays reflect the lived realities of transnationalism, where people must make homes and identities out of what’s available.

Language, Signage, and Cultural Layers

Signs directly glued to TV sets often include messages in multiple languages. For example, a TV in Chinatown advertises a Jet Li film with both Chinese and English signs. One message promotes a Taiwanese holiday sale; another offers senior bus passes. These signs reflect different audiences—locals, immigrants, tourists—and show how TVs can speak differently to different people at the same time.

Conclusion

The article concludes that TVs in transnational urban spaces are not just sources of media content but are active cultural objects that bind people to both their past and their present. The “misuse value” of the TV lies in its ability to absorb and reflect multiple layers of social, cultural, and spatial meaning. Rather than being neutral or monolithic, the TV becomes a site for everyday expression, adaptation, and identity-making.

McCarthy calls for more attention to how objects like TVs are used in real, grounded spaces. These “TV settings” challenge the idea that media only connects us to distant places—they also root us in local, lived experience.

9. Digital Gambling

This article is based on ethnographic research in Las Vegas and examines how digital gambling machines are intentionally designed to create deeply absorbing player experiences. Schüll explores how technology and human desire intersect, especially in how machines are built to keep players playing for longer periods while spending more money. The goal of the gaming industry is to merge technology and psychology so tightly that players become completely immersed in the game.

The Evolution of Slot Machines

Traditional mechanical slot machines evolved significantly with the addition of the random number generator (RNG), which allows for fast and unpredictable play outcomes. These machines gradually became digital, allowing more control, variety, and data collection. The gaming industry started to resemble modern capitalism's drive to optimize space, time, and money, blending surveillance, entertainment, and psychological manipulation.

Increasing Speed and Reducing Friction

Digital technologies allow for faster gameplay. Designers replaced physical pull handles with buttons and eventually with touchscreens. Players can now play hundreds of rounds per hour with little physical movement. Machines use bill acceptors and credit systems that eliminate the need to insert coins, making money feel less real and reducing interruptions. This design increases what the industry calls "time on device," meaning how long a player stays at a machine. Ergonomic chairs, slanted screens, and other comfort-focused innovations further reduce reasons for players to stop.

Customization and Control

Machines are designed to meet the desires of different types of players. Developers adjust game payouts, styles, and speeds to target specific player profiles. Some machines let users switch between different games or view television without leaving the seat. Others provide drink service or allow financial transactions without leaving the game. Players believe they are making choices, but many of these decisions are illusions—like "bonus rounds" that appear skill-based but are actually pre-programmed.

Psychological Manipulation Through Reinforcement

The design of games leverages psychological techniques like variable ratio reinforcement—where rewards are unpredictable—to keep players engaged. Small, frequent wins and near misses keep people playing even when they are losing money. Visual and audio effects like flashing lights and coin sounds enhance this manipulation. Multiple paylines and betting options multiply the potential outcomes and trick the player into thinking they are winning more than they actually are.

The Zone: Psychological State of Immersion

Gamblers describe entering "the zone," a trance-like state where they are fully absorbed in the game, detached from their surroundings, and unaware of time or money. In this state, players avoid social interaction, seek uninterrupted play, and prioritize speed. The machine becomes an extension of their body. Some even say they forget they are playing with real money, treating credits as meaningless. Winning too much or being interrupted can break the trance and is often seen as undesirable.

AutoPlay and the Disappearance of the Player

In extreme cases, players abandon all interaction and use features like AutoPlay, where the game plays itself. In North America, players simulate AutoPlay by jamming buttons with toothpicks. At this point, the machine absorbs all control and the player simply watches the credits go up and down. Desire and design collapse into one seamless loop—the machine responds instantly to player inputs, and eventually, those inputs disappear. The machine continues without need for human decisions.

Surveillance and Data Collection

Modern machines don't just deliver play—they record everything. Casinos use digital systems to track each player's behavior: what they play, how long, how much they bet, how often they visit, even how many drinks they consume. These machines are connected to central computers, creating networks that extend even beyond casinos into other public locations like supermarkets. Every player interaction becomes part of a data-driven feedback loop used to optimize machines and extract more profit.

Final Thoughts

Schüll concludes that digital gambling machines are not just about entertainment but are tools of modern capitalist control. They reduce time, body, labor, and money into interchangeable parts in a system of continuous productivity. These technologies don't just extend past methods of control—they accelerate and intensify them. Players no longer interact with a mechanical device, but with a digital system that absorbs desire, time, money,

and even the self. In the end, what remains is the digital logic of the machine itself, endlessly repeating the play loop without pause.

10. Interkom in Indonesia

Interkom is an indigenous Indonesian technology, a homemade communication network that connects households, food stalls (warung), and other local spaces through a system of cables. Unlike state-controlled communication systems, interkom operates informally, outside government regulation. It functions similarly to a telephone party line but culturally resembles Citizen Band (CB) radio, allowing users to chat, share music, and exchange information.

Evolution of Interkom Networks

Interkom networks have evolved over time, starting as small, localized connections within neighborhoods (kampung) and expanding into larger, long-distance lines called jalur lintas. The growth of these networks is rhizomatic—spreading unpredictably like plant roots—rather than following a centralized or hierarchical structure. Networks often split due to overcrowding, the need for privacy, or to accommodate different types of content, such as music or polite conversation.

Community and Social Dynamics

Interkom fosters a unique sense of community. Initially, it strengthened familial and neighborhood ties, but as networks expanded, they created new social bonds. Users often describe interkom relationships in terms of kinship, even though membership is voluntary and non-exclusive. The technology also enables social activities like gatherings, feasts, and outings, reinforcing community cohesion.

On-Air vs. On-Land Identities

A striking feature of interkom culture is the distinction between "on-air" (di udara) and "on-land" (di darat) identities. Users adopt on-air names and personas, often experimenting with voice modulation to create appealing sounds. This separation allows for freer, more playful interactions compared to face-to-face communication, though social hierarchies and respect for elders still influence discourse.

Cornering: The Art of Flirtation

The dominant speech genre on interkom is pojok-memojok (cornering), a form of flirtatious banter between two users, often of the opposite sex. While cornering can lead to long-term on-air partnerships, these relationships are generally kept separate from real-life commitments to avoid conflicts. The performative nature of cornering—where conversations are heard by many listeners—adds a layer of public intimacy to the practice.

Interkom and the State

Unlike other communication technologies in Indonesia, interkom has largely remained independent of state control. Early attempts to integrate it into state surveillance systems, such as neighborhood security networks, were short-lived. Users preferred to keep interkom informal and fun, resisting institutionalization.

Conclusion: A Voice-to-Voice Community

Interkom represents a hybrid form of community—neither fully imagined like a nation nor purely face-to-face like a neighborhood. It extends local social ties while preserving their familiarity, creating a "voice-to-voice" network that balances novelty with comfort. The technology reflects a distinctly Indonesian modernity, shaped by informal innovation and cultural adaptability.

Final Thoughts

The essay highlights how interkom, as a grassroots technology, has woven itself into the social fabric of Indonesian communities. It offers a fascinating case study of how communication technologies can evolve outside formal structures, fostering unique forms of connection and identity.

11. JASO Prince - A stain in the picture

This article explores how people form deep emotional and psychological attachments to screens and interfaces—especially smartphones. The author uses the act of taking selfies as a lens to understand how people create identities and navigate desire through digital screens. The paper focuses on how these attachments are formed, interrupted, and influenced by larger cultural, social, and political forces. A key image used in the essay is a viral photo of children pretending to take a selfie with a slipper instead of a phone, which becomes a powerful metaphor for how people place themselves into the world of technology, even when they don't have access to it.

The Social Role of the Selfie

The selfie is described as a tool for creating identity, gaining social recognition, and showing one's value in digital society. Scholars like Marwick see selfies as a way of becoming a “micro-celebrity” on social media. Frosh describes them as everyday gestures that keep us socially connected. The author combines these views, suggesting that selfies help people create and maintain their social presence while also reflecting their inner desires and feelings.

The Gaze and the Picture

Drawing on Lacanian psychoanalysis, the paper argues that the gaze—the act of being seen—is not just about sight, but about how people imagine themselves being seen by others. When someone takes a selfie, they are not only seeing themselves but imagining how others might see them. This act creates a desire to appear a certain way. The “stain” in the picture is a metaphor for the point where this imagined self and the desire to be seen come together. It represents the invisible mark of the person's emotional investment in their image.

The Chappal Selfie and Its Meaning

The viral photo of the children holding a slipper like a phone becomes an important symbol. It shows how the act of taking a selfie is more than just technology—it's about imagination and desire. The kids create a selfie moment even without a phone. Viewers project their own emotions onto the image: some see it as joyful, others as sad or ironic. The author says the photo reveals the deeper structures of how we attach ourselves to images and screens—how we want to be seen and what we want to see.

The Atmospheric Gaze

The author describes two incidents: one where a man is scolded for taking a selfie in a temple, and another where tourists are warned not to take selfies near a dangerous cliff. In both cases, an unseen gaze—whether it is religious, natural, or social—acts as a force that interrupts the selfie. This gaze is not from a specific person, but from a larger structure that makes people feel watched and judged. It reminds us that the act of taking a selfie is not always welcomed and can be risky or inappropriate depending on the situation.

The Interface and the Repetition of Desire

On social media, people continuously scroll, swipe, and like content. These actions are repetitive, almost automatic. The author links this to psychoanalytic ideas about repetition as a search for something that is always missing. This endless scrolling becomes a ritual, like a rhythm that marks out a private territory. These small gestures at the edge of the screen help people carve out emotional space for themselves in public or digital environments. Losing this familiar interface—like when an app redesigns itself—can cause discomfort, showing how strongly people become attached to these digital rituals.

The Face as an Interface

The article explains how the face, when captured by a camera, is no longer just a personal feature but becomes an interface that can be scanned, read, and categorized by machines. For example, phones unlock with facial recognition, and surveillance cameras can track people using algorithms. The face becomes part of a larger system of visibility and control. Some artists and activists respond to this by using makeup and fashion to confuse face-recognition systems, showing how people resist the reduction of their identity to machine-readable data.

Interruptions and Resistance

The attachment to screens is fragile and can be suddenly broken. The article tells the story of a man who smashed a newly gifted phone because he couldn't understand the unfamiliar interface. The author uses this example to show how screens create comfort zones, and when these are disrupted, people may react strongly. This section also highlights broader moments when images are censored or altered to erase signs of subjectivity or discomfort—like Instagram removing a photo of menstrual blood, or governments banning facial markings like bindis in passport photos.

Surveillance, Power, and the Subject

Surveillance technologies and social media guidelines often try to erase anything that doesn't fit into their clean, regulated image of people. This includes stains, markings, and expressions of identity that don't align with dominant values. The paper argues that this effort to remove the stain is a way of removing the subject's voice and presence. Yet, people continue to reattach themselves to images, reclaim space, and form communities of resistance through shared visual expressions.

Conclusion

The author concludes that the relationship between humans and screens is shaped by desire, attachment, and power. The smartphone, as both screen and interface, becomes a space where people live out their identities, face interruptions, and perform small acts of resistance. The stain in the picture—the mark of human presence

and desire—cannot be fully erased. Even when systems try to clean up or control what is shown, people find ways to leave their trace, reclaim visibility, and create meaning through images.

12. Daston Enlightenment Calculations

The article opens with a description of the Festival of Reason in 1793, where Parisians gathered in Notre-Dame to celebrate philosophical ideals with monuments and symbols. At the same time, another monument was being created nearby—an enormous collection of logarithmic and trigonometric tables, ordered by the French government and directed by engineer Gaspard Riche de Prony. Though intended for practical use in national land surveys, the tables were never really used. Instead, they became symbolic—representing reason, precision, and the power of human calculation.

The Changing Meaning of Calculation

In the Enlightenment, calculation was considered a high intellectual pursuit linked with intelligence, reason, and even morality. Thinkers like Condillac and D'Alembert believed that intelligence meant the ability to break down and recombine ideas, just like mathematical analysis. Calculation was part of understanding and discovering truth—not merely crunching numbers. This view started to shift as calculation became associated with repetitive labor rather than intellect. By the 19th century, calculating had begun to feel like mechanical drudgery instead of a noble mental activity.

Prony's Monumental Tables

Prony's project involved calculating sine and logarithmic values to extraordinary levels of precision—up to 25 decimal places. Inspired by Adam Smith's ideas on the division of labor, Prony organized his workers like a pyramid: expert mathematicians at the top created the formulas, middle-level analysts broke them down, and a large base of semi-skilled laborers did the basic arithmetic by hand. The project created 17 massive volumes of data. Though barely used, these tables became admired for their symbolic value as a monument to reason and order.

From Intelligence to Labor

Originally, calculation was seen as a task for brilliant minds. But Prony's project challenged that idea. He proved that even people with little education could do parts of the work, as long as tasks were broken into small enough pieces. This shifted the idea of calculation from intelligence to repetitive labor. Over time, the intellectual status of calculators dropped, and women and working-class laborers were hired for such tasks. This separation between those who invent formulas and those who perform them foreshadowed the rise of machines.

Different Visions: Prony vs. Babbage

Charles Babbage, the English mathematician, admired Prony's project but interpreted it through a more industrial lens. For Babbage, the goal was automation, replacing human workers with machines. He compared the process to a factory, emphasizing speed and efficiency. In contrast, Prony saw his work more like a luxury craft—a carefully constructed, one-of-a-kind masterpiece like a fine tapestry. He valued precision and symbolic grandeur over productivity. For Prony, his “monument” was something to be preserved and admired, not mass-produced.

The Moral Dimension of Calculation

By the mid-19th century, the act of calculation was judged not just by its correctness, but by the moral discipline of the person doing it. Victorian thinkers emphasized attention, willpower, and personal responsibility. Machines and hired assistants, they argued, couldn't be trusted to be careful or conscientious. Scottish mathematician Edward Sang harshly criticized Prony's tables for relying on unverified assistants. He believed that only an independent, morally committed individual could truly ensure the accuracy of calculations. The idea of calculation shifted once more—now it wasn't just about intelligence or labor, but also about moral character.

Conclusion

Daston's article shows how calculation, once a symbol of reason and genius during the Enlightenment, gradually became associated with labor, automation, and even laziness. The meaning of calculation changed depending on who was doing it, how it was organized, and what values society placed on mental work. Prony's grand tables became a historical landmark—not because they were useful, but because they captured a moment when ideas about knowledge, work, and machines were all being redefined. The story of calculation is also a story about shifting ideas of intelligence, labor, and morality in modern history.

13. Data, AI and the Interface

This essay explores how data is produced and extracted from people's social activity at digital interfaces—like smartphones and ATMs—and how this data powers artificial intelligence (AI). It blends anthropology and data science to show that social behavior leaves behind traces, and these traces, often unnoticed by users, are

collected, processed, and used to shape user experiences and train AI models. The author argues that this data is not just a tool for analysis but holds what he calls a “surplus value of sociality”—a hidden layer of human activity that can be mined for value.

Ethnography Meets Data Science

The essay begins by comparing early anthropological fieldwork methods with data science. While both traditions critique surveys as limited, they differ in how they observe social behavior. The anthropologist joins the social life of people and records their behavior in notebooks, while data scientists collect digital footprints generated when users interact with screens. Despite their differences, both try to capture the “actuality” of behavior rather than just what people say about themselves.

Big Data and AI: From Hype to Critique

The rise of big data and AI marked a shift from hand-coded rules to machine learning systems that rely on massive datasets to “learn.” These datasets are composed of tiny bits of user behavior—like clicks, swipes, and scrolls—captured automatically at the interface. The author critiques how some tech enthusiasts believe this data offers pure truth, while anthropologists argue that all data must be interpreted and is shaped by power and culture. Big data is not neutral—it is a form of surveillance and control.

Surplus Value of Sociality

A key concept in the essay is the “surplus value of sociality.” This refers to the extra, often hidden value created in everyday digital interactions. The author illustrates this through the Walnut app, which helped people in India find working ATMs after the 2016 demonetization crisis. The app didn’t rely on people manually reporting ATM status. Instead, it read automatic SMS notifications sent by banks to users after they withdrew cash. This data—usually seen as annoying or redundant—was repurposed to help others, turning ignored information into social value.

Redundancy as Value

Redundancy here means not waste, but potential value. Just like discarded ATM receipts or text messages seem unimportant but carry useful information, the author shows that these digital leftovers are key to how platforms learn about people. Walnut turned this redundancy into a powerful tool. The idea extends to other platforms like Netflix or Uber, where every action, no matter how small, becomes part of a data trail used to design better services and smarter AI.

Interfaces as Sites of Extraction

Interfaces—such as phone apps or metro card readers—are not just tools but are where social actions are recorded, stored, and transformed into data. These actions are detached from their original context and stored in logs, ready to be analyzed later. This shift from observing people in real life to collecting data through interfaces represents a new kind of social science, where the machine acts as the observer.

Anthropologist vs Data Scientist: A Key Distinction

The essay draws a distinction between the anthropologist’s concern with the person and the data scientist’s focus on the user as an “office.” The anthropologist watches lived experience and its subtle details. In contrast, the data scientist collects structured records of behavior that are useful for prediction and manipulation. While anthropologists look for meaning in the messy, emotional, and incomplete world of people, data science seeks measurable patterns to influence behavior.

The Machinic Unconscious

Another central idea is the “machinic unconscious.” This refers to the unconscious actions people perform at the interface—like how long they look at something or what they click—that are recorded and used by machines. These actions are unknown to the user but can be interpreted by systems like AI to model human behavior. The author compares this to Walter Benjamin’s “optical unconscious,” revealed by photography. Similarly, data exposes hidden patterns of behavior.

The Role of Nudges and Traps

Modern interfaces are designed to influence users through subtle nudges—like changing the position of a button or the color of a notification. These changes are tested using A/B experiments, where different users see slightly different interfaces. Based on the success of certain interactions, platforms update the interface to make people more likely to act in desired ways. These nudges operate on the unconscious level and can reshape habits and decisions without the user realizing it.

Training AI with Social Traces

The essay connects these ideas to AI training. Neural networks are not programmed with rules. Instead, they are trained on huge amounts of human-labeled data to learn how to produce similar results. These datasets contain traces of the surplus value of sociality. The AI “learns” not through reasoning but by absorbing human behavior patterns, including unconscious biases and associations. These can be used to nudge not just people, but also other AI systems, as shown in adversarial attacks using GANs to trick image-recognition AIs.

Conclusion: Toward Ethical Understanding of AI

The author ends by suggesting that AI models are not just logical systems—they also contain a machinic unconscious, shaped by the social data they are trained on. Understanding AI ethics requires more than correcting biases or enforcing rules; it also demands studying the subtle, unconscious traces left by human behavior. Anthropology, with its attention to lived experience and imponderable details, offers tools for understanding the hidden layers of data that power our digital world.